

The Donor Class Is Not the Electorate

Who funds elections in Washington, New York, and Idaho — old, concentrated, and (where we can see party) skewed toward Democrats in a blue state *and* a red one — measured from individual voter-to-donor matches

Paper #3 of the electoral-health series (companion to [who-decides-washington.md](#), [who-decides-new-york.md](#), [who-decides-idaho.md](#), [safe-seat-washington.md](#), and [cross-state-fec-money.md](#)). DRAFT — pending the independent-verification gate in [publication-checklist.md](#).**

Provenance. Washington figures: `scripts/diag_wa_individual_findings.py` — WA's registered roll (5.51M) + 27.1M vote records + birthdates (`data/wa_vrdb.duckdb`), matched to FEC donors (382,408 voters). New York figures: `scripts/match_ny_voters_to_donors.py`, `scripts/backfill_ny_committee_party.py`, `scripts/diag_ny_match_bias.py`, `scripts/diag_ny_primary_participation.py`, `scripts/diag_ny_donor_extras.py`, `scripts/diag_ny_electorate_extras.py` — NY's NYSVOTER roll (13.54M; individual party enrollment + DOB; `data/ny_vrdb.duckdb`) matched to 10.02M FEC itemized contributions (`data/ny_statewide.duckdb` , 308,032 voters). Idaho figures: `scripts/match_id_voters_to_donors.py`, `scripts/backfill_id_recipient_party.py`, `scripts/diag_id_electorate_extras.py` — ID's statewide roll (1.03M; individual party affiliation + age; `data/id_vrdb.duckdb`) matched to Idaho Sunshine state campaign contributions (`data/id_statewide.duckdb` , 27,250 voters). Cross-state dollar concentration: `scripts/cross_state_fec_money.py` . Each figure below traces to one of these scripts.

One cross-state caveat up front: the WA and NY donor layers are federal (FEC itemized individual contributions); the Idaho layer is state (Idaho Sunshine) because no comparable FEC individual file is loaded for ID. That the same donor-class shape appears across two different money systems, three state partisan climates, and two age-measurement methods (DOB in WA/NY, current-roll age in ID) makes the pattern more robust, not less — but Idaho's dollar figures are not directly comparable in magnitude to the two federal layers.

The question

Campaign money is usually described by *how much* is raised. The more consequential question for representation is *whose* money it is — and whether the people who fund elections look anything like the people who vote in them. If the donor class is a representative cross-section of the electorate, money is just amplified participation. If it is a narrow, unrepresentative slice, then a distinct and self-selected population is setting the financial terms of every race before the first ballot is cast.

We can answer this at the individual level in three states by matching the registered-voter roll to itemized donors, person by person (a conservative name + ZIP match; see *Boundary of inference*). Washington supplies the demographic and behavioral cut; **New York and Idaho — which, unlike Washington, publish each voter's party — supply the dimension WA cannot: who the donor class is *partisan*-ly, and where its money goes.** And they bracket the political spectrum: New York is ~48% registered Democratic, Idaho ~63% registered Republican.

The short answer, consistent across all three states: **the donor class is not the electorate**. It is markedly older, geographically and financially concentrated in a small top tier, and — where party is observable — skewed toward Democrats while nearly excluding the largest non-partisan bloc. The striking part is that the Democratic tilt of the donor class relative to the electorate appears in deep-blue New York **and in deep-red Idaho**: it is not an artifact of a state's majority party.

Finding 1 — The donor class is old, and the skew is real

In all three states matched donors are far older than the voters they fund.

New York (`match_ny_voters_to_donors.py`) — age-band share, age as of 2024-11-05:

age band	matched donors	all active voters	2024 GE voters
18–29	3.0%	18.0%	14.1%
30–44	14.2%	25.6%	23.1%
45–64	34.9%	31.2%	34.6%

age band	matched donors	all active voters	2024 GE voters
65+	47.9%	25.2%	28.2%

Nearly **half of NY's matched donors are 65 or older**, versus a quarter of the active roll. **Washington** shows the same shape as generation multipliers (donor share ÷ roll share): **Silent 1.87×**, **Boomer 1.64×**, **Gen X 1.18×**, **Millennial 0.59×**, **Gen Z 0.17×**.

Idaho replicates it in a third state (age here is current-roll age, not election-time DOB, so bands are read against the current roll):

age band	matched donors	all voters	2024 GE voters
18–29	2.6%	15.2%	13.1%
30–44	13.1%	22.8%	22.4%
45–64	33.2%	30.9%	31.9%
65+	51.1%	31.0%	32.6%

More than **half of Idaho's matched donors are 65+** — the oldest donor layer of the three — versus a third of the roll, and the under-30 share collapses to 2.6%. The donor class is the grayest slice of the electorate in blue and red states alike.

The skew is not a matching artifact. The obvious objection is that the match key (last name + first name + ZIP5, required to be *unique* on the roll) selects older, rarer-named, stable-address voters. Tested directly in the two states where we ran the re-weighting (WA and NY), it does not: the probability a voter is uniquely matchable is **nearly flat across age** — NY **94.5–95.4%** across the four bands (0.9-pt spread, `diag_ny_match_bias.py`); WA **68.9%–73.1%** across generations (~4-pt spread). Inverse-propensity re-weighting therefore **barely moves the distribution**: NY's 65+ donor share goes 47.9% → **47.9%** (0.0-pt shift); WA's Silent multiplier 1.87 → **1.83×**, Gen Z 0.17 → **0.17×**. The age skew is a property of who *gives*, not of who the matcher can *find*. (Idaho uses the identical conservative matcher but was not separately re-weighted; its 51% 65+ donor share is reported without that adjustment.)

Finding 2 — The donor class is whale-dominated

Money concentrates at the very top of the matched-donor distribution, similarly across three very different states:

matched-donor concentration	Washington	New York	Idaho
top 1% of donors → share of matched \$	47.7%	51.2%	39.3%
top 10% of donors → share of matched \$	80.0%	81.4%	70.8%

*Estimator (all three states, one method): donors are ranked by total matched dollars and split into 100 equal-count buckets (`NTILE(100)`) over actual donors (`total_donated > 0`); "top 1% / 10%" is the top 1 / 10 buckets' dollars ÷ all matched dollars. Equal-count buckets are robust to ties at round dollar amounts; an earlier draft computed NY and Idaho with `PERCENT_RANK`, which drifts from an exact decile at small *N* — it read Idaho's top-10% as 69.0% rather than 70.8%. Gini coefficients: WA 0.862, NY 0.867, Idaho 0.798.*

A geographic corollary in all three states. In WA, **61.2%** of matched-donor dollars come from just two Seattle-metro ZIP3s (981xx 35.9% + 980xx 25.2%). NY is even more concentrated: **Manhattan (New York County) alone supplies 50.3%** of matched-donor dollars, ZIP3 100 = 46.3%, and the top three ZIP3s (Manhattan + Westchester + Brooklyn) = **63.4%** (`diag_ny_donor_extras.py`). Idaho shows the same single-metro dominance: **Ada County (Boise) alone supplies 49.2%** of matched-donor dollars from 10,037 donors — the money mirror of Seattle and Manhattan in a state with neither. (Idaho's top-1% concentration, 39%, is somewhat lower than the two federal layers — expected, since state contribution limits compress the very top of the state-money distribution.) At the statewide level (all itemized donors, not only matched), the same top-heaviness appears across all four states we have loaded — top 1% of donors supply **39.3%** of dollars in WA, **47.5%** in NY, **41.7%** in TX, and **36.0%** in ID (`cross_state_fec_money.py`). The "small-dollar democratization" narrative coexists with a money system whose itemized dollars are dominated by a thin top stratum and a single metro.

Finding 3 — The donor class is partisan-skewed toward Democrats (New York and Idaho)

This is the cut Washington cannot supply. Using each donor's **own** NY party enrollment (100% present), the donor class over-represents registered Democrats and **nearly excludes the unaffiliated**:

party	matched donors	donor share	registration	skew	matched \$	\$ share
DEM	193,355	62.8%	47.8%	+15.0	\$849.2M	71.0%
REP	65,898	21.4%	22.3%	-0.9	\$197.2M	16.5%
NOPARTY (blank)	38,601	12.5%	25.5%	-13.0	\$126.8M	10.6%
OTHER (minor)	10,178	3.3%	4.4%	-1.1	\$22.8M	1.9%

Registered Democrats are +15 points over their share of the roll and supply **71% of matched dollars**; Republicans give roughly in proportion; and NY's "blank" (no-party) enrollees — **a quarter of all registrants** — are only an eighth of donors. The donor class is not a scaled-down electorate but a partisan-skewed slice that runs *against* the largest non-partisan bloc.

Where the money goes — crossover. After resolving recipient party for 79% of contributions via the bulk FEC committee + candidate masters (`backfill_ny_committee_party.py`):

own party	donors (resolved)	→ Democratic	→ Republican	mixed
DEM	174,330	94.2%	3.9%	1.9%
REP	57,342	14.2%	82.6%	3.2%
NOPARTY	30,590	65.5%	31.0%	3.5%
OTHER	8,274	40.7%	57.0%	2.3%

Two patterns: registered **Republicans fund Democrats at ~3.6× the rate Democrats fund Republicans** (14.2% vs 3.9%) — a deep-blue donor ecosystem; and the unaffiliated bloc, invisible to registration-based analysis, **leans ~2:1 Democratic in its actual giving** (65.5% → D), so NY's independents are not centrist by behavior.

Idaho — the same skew, in the reddest state. The decisive test of whether the Democratic tilt of the donor class is real or just a blue-state artifact is to run it in a state where Republicans hold a 5:1 registration edge. Using each donor's own Idaho affiliation:

party	matched donors	donor share	registration	skew	matched \$	\$ share
REP	18,115	66.5%	62.9%	+3.6	\$11.31M	71.1%
DEM	5,685	20.9%	11.8%	+9.1	\$3.27M	20.6%
UNAFF (unaffiliated)	3,281	12.0%	23.9%	-11.9	\$1.27M	8.0%
OTHER (minor)	169	0.6%	1.4%	-0.8	\$0.04M	0.3%

Republicans supply the plurality of Idaho's money, as a 63%-Republican state must — but relative to their numbers the **most over-represented donors are registered Democrats** (+9.1 points, nearly double their share of the roll), and the unaffiliated quarter is again the most *under*-represented (-11.9). The same directional finding as New York, from the opposite end of the spectrum: the donor class leans Democratic-of-the-electorate and runs against the unaffiliated, whether the electorate around it is blue or red.

Crossover (Idaho). Idaho Sunshine carries no party on the recipient, so recipient party is reconstructed from the Secretary of State candidate roster plus party/committee name patterns (`backfill_id_recipient_party.py`), resolving ~52% of matched donors and ~66% of candidate-directed dollars. Among donors whose money reached a party-resolvable recipient:

own party	donors (resolved)	→ Democratic	→ Republican	mixed
DEM	3,365	93.5%	4.0%	2.5%

own party	donors (resolved)	→ Democratic	→ Republican	mixed
REP	9,420	18.8%	79.3%	1.9%
UNAFF	1,303	72.8%	24.5%	2.7%
OTHER	59	18.6%	81.4%	0.0%

The two direction-safe patterns from New York replicate: registered **Democrats are near-monolithic donors** (93.5% → D, essentially identical to NY's 94.2%), and **unaffiliated donors lean Democratic** in their actual giving (~3:1 in ID, ~2:1 in NY) — independents are not centrist by behavior in either state. Idaho's apparent Republican→Democratic crossover (18.8%) is an **upper bound**: the unresolved recipient pool (local Republican candidates and R-aligned PACs absent from the roster) skews Republican, so Republican donors' Republican-side giving is disproportionately the part left untraced, and the ~52% coverage is well below NY's 79%. We therefore make no cross-state claim about the majority party's crossover rate — only the Democratic-loyalty and unaffiliated-lean patterns, which hold in both states.

In-state vs out-of-state, by party. Money flowing *into* NY's federal races (`fec_inflow.duckdb`, all-state donors → NY candidates; `diag_ny_donor_extras.py`) is **44.8% out-of-state for both parties** — nationalization is party-symmetric at the aggregate, consistent with the cross-state finding that out-of-state share is uniform across competitiveness (`cross-state-fec-money.md` §G). The one asymmetry is by office: NY's **Senate Democrats draw 54.1% of their money from out-of-state** (Schumer/Gillibrand as national magnets) versus ~43–45% for House candidates of both parties. So the donor class is partisan-skewed in *who it is* (§3 above) but not in *how far its money travels* — except at the marquee Senate tier.

The skew holds in every kind of district. Mapping matched donors to their congressional district's competitiveness (`diag_ny_electorate_extras.py`), the donor pool's Democratic share **exceeds the registered Democratic share in every band** — Tossup 57.7% donor vs 40% registrant, Solid 71.6% vs 56% — so the donor class is more Democratic than the electorate not just statewide but locally, regardless of how contested the seat is. And **two-thirds of donors (205K of 308K) live in Solid districts** (mostly Solid-D Manhattan): the money originates in safe seats, consistent with the cross-state finding that safe seats supply most of it. Idaho shows the same safe-seat origin from the red side: the great bulk of matched Idaho donors sit in Solid-R legislative districts (where the donor pool is 71% Republican), while the handful of more competitive districts carry a far more balanced donor mix (~46% Republican / ~34% Democratic) (`diag_id_electorate_extras.py`) — the money, in both states, originates overwhelmingly in the seats that are not in doubt.

Finding 4 — Financial voice and electoral voice stack on the same people

In both states, the people who give are the people who reliably vote. In Washington, matched donors are **84.0% super-voters versus 50.1%** of non-donors (mean turnout propensity 0.953 vs 0.748). In New York, matched donors voted in **3.01 of the last four federal generals on average versus 1.85** for non-donors, and **72.9% are super-voters (≥3 of 4) versus 39.3%** (`diag_ny_donor_extras.py`). The same individuals concentrate *both* forms of influence rather than one offsetting the other. (Association only — donors are pre-selected for engagement, so reverse causation is equally plausible; the benign "donating as a gateway to participation" reading is fully live.)

A closed-primary corollary at the nominating stage, in both party-of-record states. NY's **closed** primaries restrict each party's primary to its enrollees, so the **25.3% enrolled "blank" are excluded by law** (~0.1–0.6% primary participation), and in blue NY the Democratic primary is frequently the decisive contest (2021 odd-year DEM 16.9% vs REP 5.0%). Idaho is the mirror image: its **closed Republican primary is the decisive contest** in nearly every seat (80–86% of all primary ballots are Republican; see `who-decides-idaho.md`), and the unaffiliated quarter is excluded in practice — **6.6% primary participation vs 83% in the November general**. The population that nominates is small and party-gated in both states — and, per Finding 3, funded by a donor class narrower and more skewed still.

Boundary of inference

- **The match is a proxy.** Voter↔donor identity rests on (last, first, ZIP5) uniqueness, not a shared ID. It is conservative by design (ambiguous keys are dropped, not guessed), so the matched set is a **floor**, not a census, of the donor population. WA bootstrap CIs on concentration are tight; a 150-row hand-validation of match precision (2026-07-10, two review rounds) finds **≈90% apparent precision** (15/150 flagged on a second, more thorough pass; 9 on the first), the dominant error being **spousal/household false-merges** (same surname + ZIP). Those barely move the age, geography, or concentration cuts, because the mis-attributed partner shares household, ZIP, and typically similar age;

some flags were unverifiable for missing donor detail, so true precision may be a little higher.

- **Itemized giving; federal for WA/NY, state for ID.** Sub-\$200 unitemized giving is invisible, so the *small-dollar* end is undercounted — which, if anything, **understates** the concentration in Findings 1–2. WA/NY use FEC federal itemized contributions; **Idaho uses Idaho Sunshine state contributions** (no comparable FEC individual file is loaded for ID), so ID dollar *magnitudes* are not comparable to the federal layers — only the within-state shares and skews are. That the same shape recurs across the two money systems strengthens the finding.
- **Active-roll denominator.** All three matches use the current roll; past-purged donors are absent, biasing turnout *rates* (not composition shares) high for older cycles. Read shares as the robust cut. Idaho's age is a current-roll integer (not DOB), so ID age bands are current-age, not election-time.
- **Recipient party (Finding 3 crossover) covers 79% of NY contributions and ~52% of ID matched donors** (~66% of ID candidate-directed dollars); unresolved rows are genuinely-nonpartisan PACs / ballot-measure committees in both. The ID majority-party crossover rate is an upper bound (see Finding 3); own-party and age cuts use the full 100%-present party of record.
- **One residual age bias runs one way.** A donor who moved between giving and today fails the ZIP match, and mobility skews young — deflating the young donor share. So the raw age skew is an **upper bound**, but the specific mechanism the objection names (rare names → easier match for the old) is ruled out by the flat P(matchable) above.

What it means

Across three states that differ in size, partisanship, money system, and election administration, the population that finances campaigns is the same kind of population: **old, top-heavy, geographically concentrated, and — where party is observable — skewed toward Democrats relative to the electorate and away from the unaffiliated.** New York and Idaho's party-of-record turns the Washington finding from "the donor class is demographically unrepresentative" into the sharper, falsifiable claim that it is *also* partisan-unrepresentative in a specific direction — and, critically, in the **same** direction in a deep-blue and a deep-red state, so the Democratic tilt is a property of who donates, not of a state's majority party. Combined with the turnout and safe-seat papers, the picture is a series of narrowing filters between the registered population and actual influence — who votes, who votes in the decisive primary, and who pays — each one older and less representative than the last. This is the evidentiary core of the electoral-health series' "donor class ≠ electorate" finding, now resolved by party across the spectrum.

Methods & reproducibility

```
# Washington (no external file needed):
python scripts/diag_wa_individual_findings.py

# New York:
python scripts/load_ny_voters.py                # NYSVOTER FOIL -> ny_vrdb.duckdb
python scripts/diag_ny_turnout_party.py --rebuild # voter_participation table
python scripts/backfill_ny_committee_party.py    # bulk FEC committee/candidate party -> 79%
STATE=NY python scripts/match_ny_voters_to_donors.py # match + own-party/age/crossover
STATE=NY python scripts/diag_ny_match_bias.py     # age-skew validation
STATE=NY python scripts/diag_ny_primary_participation.py
STATE=NY python scripts/diag_ny_donor_extras.py   # geography, giving<=>turnout, in/out-of-state

# Idaho (state Sunshine money; party of record + current-roll age):
python scripts/load_id_voters.py                # ID SoS voter file -> id_vrdb.duckdb
STATE=ID python scripts/backfill_id_recipient_party.py # recipient party from SoS roster + patterns
STATE=ID python scripts/match_id_voters_to_donors.py # match + own-party/age/concentration/crossover
python scripts/diag_id_electorate_extras.py      # donor-mix x LD competitiveness

# Cross-state dollar concentration:
python scripts/cross_state_fec_money.py
```

All inputs are public records (FEC bulk files; state voter files obtained under each state's lawful-use terms — NY NYSVOTER FOIL, WA VRDB). See [data-sources-and-reproducibility.md](#) for the full source ledger and the matcher/competitiveness method notes.